How to Write a Case Study Report

Step-by-Step Guide

A Thesis Guide

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Abstract

A case study is an in-depth investigation of one person, group, organisation, event or place, carried out in its real-life setting. It is one of the most widely used research methods in education, business, health, social work, law and the social sciences, because it answers the questions that surveys and experiments cannot: not only what happened, but how and why it happened. This guide explains, step by step, how to design, conduct and write up a case study report that is rigorous, honest and readable.

The guide covers the whole process. It begins by explaining what a case study is and when it is the right method, and describes the main types: exploratory, descriptive and explanatory studies, and single-case and multiple-case designs. It then shows how to choose a case, frame research questions and propositions, and collect evidence from interviews, documents and observation. It explains triangulation, the practice of checking findings against several sources of evidence, and the main strategies for analysing case study data, including pattern matching and explanation building. Later chapters deal with the structure of the report itself, how to write findings with evidence, and the ethical duties of confidentiality and informed consent.

Throughout, the emphasis is practical. Each chapter includes worked examples, sample tables and checklists that a student can use while planning, carrying out and writing up the study. A complete fictional worked example in Chapter 11 shows how all the pieces fit together, from the research question to the final recommendations. The guide is written for undergraduate and postgraduate students who are writing a case study for the first time, and it assumes no previous experience of qualitative research.

Keywords: case study; qualitative research; triangulation; pattern matching; research design; ethics

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How to use this guide: read Chapters 1 to 4 before you begin, to design the study properly. Chapters 5 to 7 guide you while you collect and analyse the data. Chapters 8 and 9 guide the writing itself. Chapter 11 is a complete worked example to read alongside your own draft, and Chapter 12 is a final check before submission.

Chapter 1: What a Case Study Is

A case study is a detailed investigation of a single instance of something: one school, one company, one hospital ward, one classroom, one village, one event, or one person. The researcher studies that instance in depth, in its natural setting, using several kinds of evidence, in order to understand it thoroughly and to explain how and why things happened as they did. The case is the unit of study, and everything in the research is organised around it.

The case study is different from the other methods you may have met. A survey collects a little information from many people; a case study collects a great deal of information about one case. An experiment controls conditions in order to test a cause; a case study accepts conditions as they are and studies them as they unfold. A history relies on documents about the past; a case study usually studies something happening now, and can use direct observation and interviews with the people involved. This closeness to real life is the method's greatest strength and its greatest challenge.

1.1 When a case study is the right method

A case study is the right choice when your research question asks how or why

something happens, when you cannot control the events you are studying, and when the context matters to the answer. If you want to know how a school introduced a new reading programme and why some teachers adopted it while others resisted, a case study of that school will serve you better than a survey of a hundred schools, because the answer lies in the details: the meetings, the timetables, the personalities, the history of the school. A survey could tell you how many teachers resisted; only a case study can tell you why.

It is also the right choice when the case itself is interesting or unusual. A single hospital that reduced waiting times dramatically, a business that survived a crisis that destroyed its competitors, or a community project that succeeded where others failed — each of these deserves close study, because understanding one remarkable case can teach us things that a broad survey would miss. Finally, a case study is often the only practical choice for a student researcher: you may have access to one school, one clinic or one organisation, and a deep study of that one place is a realistic and valuable project.

1.2 What a case study is not

A case study is not a story. A good report may read well, but it is not written for entertainment; every claim must be supported by evidence, and the evidence must be shown to the reader. It is not a single interview or a single visit, either. A case study draws on several sources of evidence, gathered systematically over time. And it is not a piece of advocacy: the researcher studies the case as it is, including its failures and contradictions, rather than presenting it as a success story. If you find yourself hiding awkward evidence because it spoils a neat story, you have stopped doing research and started doing publicity.

1.3 Strengths and limitations

The strengths of the case study are depth, context and richness. It can capture the complexity of real life, show how different factors interact, and produce findings that feel true to the people involved. It is flexible: if the first interviews raise an unexpected question, the researcher can follow it. Its main limitation is that the findings from one case cannot simply be generalised to all similar cases. A case study does not prove that what happened in one school will happen in every school. What it can do is show, in detail, how a process works — and that understanding can then be tested in other settings. A careful researcher states this limit openly and does not claim more than the evidence supports.

[ ] My research question asks how or why something happens in a real setting.

[ ] I can name the case: one school, organisation, group, event or person.

[ ] I have realistic access to the case and to the people involved.

[ ] I understand that one case cannot prove a general rule.

Chapter 2: Types of Case Study

Case studies come in several types, and the type you choose shapes everything that follows: what data you collect, how you analyse it, and how you write the report. The most useful distinction is between exploratory, descriptive and explanatory studies, based on the purpose of the research. A second distinction is between single-case and multiple-case designs, based on how many cases you study. Most student projects are descriptive or explanatory studies of a single case, but it is important to choose deliberately rather than by accident.

2.1 Exploratory case studies

An exploratory case study is used when little is known about the topic and the researcher is trying to find out what the important questions are. The study is open-ended: the researcher gathers a wide range of evidence, looks for patterns, and ends with a set of questions or ideas that a later, larger study can test. Exploratory studies are common at the start of a research programme, or when a new phenomenon appears — a new technology in classrooms, a new kind of community organisation — and nobody yet knows what matters about it. The report of an exploratory study is honest about its open-ended character: it offers findings and questions, not final answers.

2.2 Descriptive case studies

A descriptive case study gives a full and careful account of a case: what happened, who was involved, in what order, and in what context. It does not try to explain causes in depth, and it does not test a theory. Its value lies in the quality of the description itself. A descriptive study of how one school organises its timetable, or how one clinic manages its patients, can be extremely useful to practitioners in similar settings, because it shows them, step by step, what the practice actually looks like. Good description is harder than it sounds: it requires careful observation, accurate records, and the discipline to report what happened rather than what the researcher expected to happen.

2.3 Explanatory case studies

An explanatory case study goes further: it tries to explain why something happened. It starts with an idea about the cause — a proposition, or a theory — and tests it against the evidence from the case. If the evidence fits, the explanation gains support; if it does not fit, the explanation must be revised. Explanatory studies are the most demanding type, because they require clear thinking about causes and careful comparison of rival explanations. They are also the most rewarding, because a convincing explanation of one case can change how people understand a whole class of problems.

Type	Main purpose	Typical question

Exploratory	Discover what matters; raise questions	What is happening here, and why might it matter?
Descriptive	Give a full, careful account	What happened, and in what order?
Explanatory	Test an explanation of why it happened	Why did this happen, and does the evidence support the explanation?

2.4 Single-case and multiple-case designs

A single-case design studies one case in great depth. It is the right choice when the case is unique, when it is a critical test of a theory, or when it is simply the case you have access to. A multiple-case design studies two or more cases — for example, three schools that introduced the same programme — and compares them. The comparison makes the findings stronger: if the same pattern appears in all three schools, the explanation is more convincing than if it appears in only one. Multiple-case studies take more time, so a student researcher should be realistic: two or three cases studied well are worth more than five cases studied superficially. Whichever design you choose, state it clearly in the report and explain why you chose it.

Worked Example: Choosing the type

A student wants to study how a local library runs a reading club for children. If little is known about such clubs, an exploratory study can map what happens and raise questions. If the aim is to document the club so other libraries can copy it, a descriptive study is right. If the student believes the club succeeds because parents are involved, and wants to test that explanation, an explanatory study is the choice. The same case, three different studies — and the report must make clear which one was done.

[ ] I have chosen one type: exploratory, descriptive or explanatory.

[ ] My research question matches the type I have chosen.

[ ] I have decided between a single case and multiple cases, and I can say why.

[ ] The number of cases fits the time and access I actually have.

Chapter 3: Choosing the Case

The choice of case is the most important decision in a case study, because the whole project stands or falls on it. A good case is one that can answer your research question, that you can genuinely access, and that is interesting enough to repay months of close attention. Students often choose a case for the wrong reasons — because it is familiar, because it is convenient, or because someone suggested it — and then discover too late that it cannot answer their question. Take time over this choice, and discuss it with your supervisor before you commit.

3.1 What makes a good case?

First, the case must be relevant to the question. If your question is about how small shops survive competition from large stores, your case should be a small shop facing exactly that competition, not a large store or a shop in a market with no competitors. Second, the case must be information-rich: there must be people willing to talk, documents to read, and events to observe. A case where nobody will speak to you is not a case study; it is a dead end. Third, the case should be bounded — it must have clear edges. A case defined as 'the school' is manageable; a case defined as 'education in the district' is not. Write down the boundaries: the place, the people, the time period, and the activities included. Everything outside those boundaries is outside the study.

3.2 Access and permission

Access must be negotiated before the study begins, and it must be negotiated honestly. Approach the person in charge, explain what the study is about, what you will ask people to do, how much time it will take, and how you will protect their privacy. Get the permission in writing, and keep a copy. Be prepared for conditions: the organisation may ask to see the draft report before it is submitted, or may ask that certain details be left out. Reasonable conditions can be accepted; a condition that you must only report positive findings cannot. If access is refused, do not argue or sneak in through a side door. Choose another case.

3.3 The case study protocol

Before collecting data, write a short protocol: a document of a few pages that states the research question, the boundaries of the case, the sources of evidence you will use, the people you hope to interview, the documents you hope to see, and the timetable. The protocol keeps the study focused, and it gives your supervisor something concrete to comment on. It is not a rigid contract — case study research is flexible, and the protocol will change as you learn more — but starting without one is like starting a journey without a map. Update the protocol as the study develops, and keep the old versions so that the reader can see how the study evolved.

Worked Example: Defining the boundaries

A student studying homework in a primary school defines the case as: one Grade 5 class, in one named school (fictional name used in the report), over one school term,

covering homework in mathematics and English only. The boundaries exclude other grades, other subjects and homework set during holidays. This definition is narrow enough to study deeply in one term, and clear enough that a reader knows exactly what the study covers — and what it does not.

[ ] The case can answer my research question.

[ ] I have written permission to study the case.

[ ] The boundaries of the case are written down: place, people, time, activities.

[ ] I have a short protocol with my question, sources and timetable.

Chapter 4: Research Questions and Propositions

Every case study needs a clear research question. Without one, data collection becomes aimless: the researcher gathers everything, interviews everyone, and ends with a mountain of material and no argument. The question is the compass of the study. It tells you what evidence to collect, whom to interview, which documents to request, and what to leave out. Write it early, write it as one sentence, and test every new line of inquiry against it: does this help answer the question? If not, set it aside.

4.1 From a topic to a question

Students usually start with a topic: 'homework', 'staff turnover', 'patient waiting times'. A topic is not a question, because it does not say what the study will find out. Turn the topic into a question by adding the words how or why, and by naming the case. 'Homework' becomes 'How do Grade 5 pupils in one primary school experience homework, and what do their parents and teachers think of it?' This version names the case, the people and the focus, and it can be answered with evidence. One main question is enough for a student project; add two or three sub-questions if the main question has distinct parts, but no more. Each sub-question should follow clearly from the main one.

4.2 Propositions: what you expect to find

In an explanatory case study, the researcher states propositions before collecting data: short statements of what the researcher expects to find, and why. A proposition is not a guess; it is a reasoned expectation drawn from earlier reading or from experience. For example: 'Teachers who set homework with a clear purpose will report fewer complaints from parents than teachers who set homework as a routine.' The proposition is then tested against the evidence: the interviews, the documents and the observations either support it or they do not. Propositions are valuable because they stop the researcher from collecting data without direction, and they make the analysis honest — the researcher must report when a proposition fails, not only when it succeeds. Descriptive and exploratory studies may not need formal propositions, but even there it helps to write down, in a paragraph, what you expect and what would surprise you.

4.3 Rival explanations

A strong explanatory study considers rival explanations from the start. If homework complaints fall after a new policy is introduced, the policy may be the cause — but so may a change of teacher, a smaller class, or a new headteacher. Listing the rivals in advance protects the researcher from a common trap: finding one plausible explanation and stopping. During analysis, each rival is checked against the evidence and either supported or ruled out. The report should show this work: the reader should be able to see that alternatives were considered and why the favoured explanation survived. A study that has defeated its rivals is far more convincing than one that never noticed them.

Worked Example: Question, sub-questions and proposition

Main question: 'Why did the reading programme succeed in one school and fail in another?' Sub-questions: 'How was the programme introduced in each school? How did teachers respond? What support did they receive?' Proposition: 'The programme succeeded where the headteacher attended training alongside the teachers, and failed where training was given to teachers alone.' Rival explanation: 'The difference was caused by class size, not by leadership.' The study then gathers evidence on both.

[ ] My main research question is written as one clear sentence.

[ ] I have at most three sub-questions, each following from the main one.

[ ] For an explanatory study, my propositions are written down before data collection.

[ ] I have listed at least one rival explanation to check.

Chapter 5: Data Collection: Interviews, Documents, Observation

A case study is only as good as its evidence, and good evidence comes from several sources collected systematically. The three main sources are interviews, documents and observation, and most studies use all three. Interviews tell you what people think and why; documents tell you what was decided and recorded; observation tells you what actually happens, which is sometimes different from both. Plan the data collection before you begin, keep careful records as you go, and store everything securely so that you — and your supervisor — can check it later.

5.1 Interviews

Interviews are usually the main source of evidence in a case study. Plan whom to interview by asking who can answer the research question: the people who run the programme, the people who use it, and the people who decided to fund it may each see it differently, and all three views matter. Prepare an interview guide: a list of open questions, in a sensible order, with prompts for follow-up. The guide keeps the interview focused, but it is not a script — if the interviewee raises something important that is not on the list, follow it. Listen more than you talk, ask for examples ('Can you tell me about a time when that happened?'), and record the interview with permission so that you can quote accurately. Take notes as well, in case the

recording fails.

After each interview, write up your notes the same day, while the conversation is fresh. Note the main points, any striking phrases, and your own first impressions. Transcribe the recording fully if you can; if time does not allow, transcribe the key passages word for word and summarise the rest. A transcript is the raw material of the analysis, and a study built on vague memories of interviews is a weak study. Aim for enough interviews to cover the main viewpoints — in a student project this is often between eight and fifteen — and stop when new interviews stop adding new ideas.

5.2 Documents

Documents are a rich and underused source. Meeting minutes, reports, letters, policies, timetables, newsletters, budgets, photographs and press cuttings can all be evidence. They are useful in two ways: they record what happened, often with dates, and they show how the organisation presents itself. Collect documents systematically, note where each one came from and when it was written, and keep a log so that every document cited in the report can be traced. Be critical: a document was written for a purpose, and that purpose may shape what it says. A progress report written to secure funding will describe success; an internal memo may describe problems. Both are evidence, but they must be read with their purpose in mind.

5.3 Observation

Observation means watching what happens in the case, in its normal setting, and recording it carefully. You might sit in on meetings, watch lessons, or spend time in a workplace. Observation is valuable because people do not always do what they say they do: a teacher may describe a new method enthusiastically in an interview and then use the old method in the classroom. Observation catches that gap. Before observing, agree with the people involved what you will watch and how long you will stay, and take care to be as unobtrusive as possible. Write field notes during or immediately after each session, separating what you saw from what you thought about it: 'The teacher spoke for twenty minutes without a question from the class' is an observation; 'The teacher was boring' is a judgement.

5.4 Keeping a case study database

From the first day, keep everything in one organised place: transcripts, documents, field notes, photographs, the protocol, and a log of every contact. Give each item a clear name and date, and keep a simple index. This collection is the case study database, and it is what makes the study auditable: your supervisor or examiner can see exactly what evidence each finding rests on. A student who keeps good records will write the report far more easily than one who must search through scattered notebooks at the end. Back the database up regularly, and keep it secure, especially where it contains personal information.

Worked Example: Planning the evidence

A student studying a school's new homework policy plans: ten interviews (the headteacher, four teachers, three parents, two pupils), documents (the policy, the minutes of the meeting that adopted it, and two terms of homework records), and observation (six homework-setting sessions in class). Each source is chosen to answer a specific part of the question, and the plan is written into the protocol before fieldwork begins.

[ ] My interview guide is written, with open questions and follow-ups.

[ ] I have a list of documents to request, with their sources noted.

[ ] Observation sessions are agreed, with dates and times.

[ ] Every item of evidence is filed and dated in one database.

Chapter 6: Triangulation: Using Several Sources

Triangulation is the practice of checking a finding against more than one source of evidence. If the interviews, the documents and the observations all point in the same direction, the finding is strong. If they disagree, the disagreement itself is important: it must be investigated and explained, not hidden. Triangulation is the case study researcher's main defence against the charge that the findings are just one person's opinion, and it is what separates a serious study from a single interview dressed up as research.

6.1 Data triangulation

Data triangulation means using different sources of data on the same question. A claim that teachers dislike a new policy is weak if it rests on one interview. It becomes strong if several teachers say it, the minutes of a staff meeting record the complaints, and observation shows teachers quietly avoiding the policy in practice. Plan triangulation into the study from the start: for each important question, ask yourself which sources could answer it, and collect at least two. When you write the report, show the reader the convergence: 'Teachers, parents and the homework records all indicate that...' is a sentence that carries weight precisely because it names several sources.

6.2 Method triangulation and investigator triangulation

Method triangulation means using different methods — interviews, documents and observation — on the same question, as described above. Investigator triangulation means having more than one researcher look at the same evidence. A student researcher working alone cannot easily arrange this, but there are substitutes: ask your supervisor to read a sample of transcripts and check your coding; or ask a fellow student to code three interviews independently and compare the results. Even a small check of this kind strengthens the study, and it is worth describing in the report. A third form, theory triangulation, means looking at the evidence through more than one theoretical lens — for example, asking whether a finding can be explained both by leadership theory and by workload. Use it where it fits your study, but do not force it.

6.3 What to do when sources disagree

Sources will disagree, and that is normal. A headteacher may describe a programme as a success while the teachers describe it as a burden; a document may record a decision that nobody remembers making. Do not resolve the disagreement by choosing the source you like best. Investigate it: ask further questions, look for more documents, observe again. Sometimes the disagreement is a matter of perspective — both accounts are true from different positions — and the report should present both. Sometimes one source is wrong, and further evidence will show which. Either way, the disagreement is a finding, and a report that shows how it was handled is more trustworthy than one that pretends the evidence was neat.

Source	What it is good for	What to watch out for
Interviews	Views, reasons, experiences	People may say what they think you want to hear
Documents	Facts, dates, decisions	Written for a purpose; may present a polished picture
Observation	What actually happens	People may behave differently when watched

- [ ] Each main finding is supported by at least two sources.
- [ ] Where sources disagree, I have investigated and reported the disagreement.
- [ ] A second reader has checked a sample of my coding or analysis.
- [ ] The report shows the reader which sources support each finding.

Chapter 7: Analysis: Pattern Matching and Explanation Building

Analysis is the stage where the mass of evidence — transcripts, documents, field notes — is turned into findings. It is the hardest part of a case study, and the part students most often rush. Analysis begins while data collection is still going on, not after it ends: as you read each interview, you will notice ideas recurring, and those ideas should shape the next interview. Work through the data systematically, in stages, and keep a written record of the decisions you make, so that the reader can see how you got from the evidence to the conclusions.

7.1 Coding the data

The first step is coding: reading through the material and labelling the passages that matter. A code is a short label, such as 'time pressure', 'parent complaints', or 'lack of

training', attached to a sentence or paragraph. Start with a small set of codes drawn from your research question and propositions, and add new codes as new ideas appear in the data. Keep a codebook — a list of each code, what it means, and an example — so that your coding stays consistent from the first interview to the last. Coding is slow work, but it is the foundation of everything that follows: without it, the analysis rests on impression rather than evidence.

7.2 Pattern matching

Pattern matching is the main analytic strategy for explanatory studies. You state the pattern you would expect to see if your proposition were true, and then you compare it with the pattern actually found in the data. If the headteacher's support was the key to success, you would expect to find: the headteacher attended training, teachers mention the headteacher's support in interviews, and the programme is used regularly in classrooms. If all three are present, the proposition gains support. If only one is present, the proposition is weak. The power of pattern matching is that it tests a precise expectation against the evidence, rather than inviting the researcher to notice only the evidence that fits. Write the expected pattern down before you examine the data, so that you cannot adjust it after the fact.

7.3 Explanation building

Explanation building is a related strategy, used when the explanation is developed gradually. The researcher starts with a simple explanation, tests it against the first case or the first batch of evidence, revises it to fit what was found, and tests the revised explanation against the next batch. The process repeats until the explanation fits the evidence well. It is particularly useful in exploratory studies, where the explanation is not known in advance. The danger is that the explanation can be adjusted endlessly to fit the data, until it explains everything and predicts nothing. Guard against this by stating, at each stage, what evidence would count against the explanation, and by checking the final version against rival explanations.

7.4 Cross-case analysis

In a multiple-case study, the final step is to compare the cases. Make a table with the cases as columns and the key findings as rows, and look for patterns: which findings appear in all cases, which appear in some, and which appear in only one? A finding that appears in every case is strong; a finding that appears in one case only may be explained by something special about that case, and that difference is itself a finding. Write a short summary of each case first, then the comparison, so that the reader can follow both the individual stories and the pattern across them.

Worked Example: Pattern matching in practice

Proposition: 'The reading programme succeeded because the headteacher supported it.' Expected pattern: the headteacher attends training; teachers cite the headteacher's support; classroom observation shows the programme in regular use. In School A all three appear, and the programme succeeds. In School B the headteacher does not attend training, teachers do not mention support, and the programme is rarely used — and it

fails. The pattern matches the proposition in both schools, so the explanation gains support. If School B had succeeded without the headteacher's support, the proposition would have to be revised.

[ ] I have a codebook, and my coding is consistent across the data.

[ ] For each proposition, I wrote the expected pattern before checking the data.

[ ] Rival explanations have been tested against the evidence.

[ ] In a multiple-case study, I have compared the cases in a table.

Chapter 8: Structure of the Case Study Report

The structure of a case study report is similar to that of any research report, but the findings section is longer and richer, because the story of the case must be told as well as the analysis. A typical report has: a title page, an abstract, an introduction, a description of the case and its context, a methodology section, the findings, a discussion, a conclusion with recommendations, references, and appendices. The order matters, because the reader must understand the case before they can judge the findings, and must see the evidence before they can accept the conclusions.

8.1 Introduction and context

The introduction states the problem, the research question and the purpose of the study, and explains why the case was chosen. The context section then describes the case itself: the organisation or place, its history, its people, and the situation at the time of the study. This section is descriptive, but it is not padding. The reader needs enough detail to understand what follows, and to judge whether the findings might apply elsewhere. Give the facts that matter — size, location, key people, the sequence of events — and leave out the rest. Use fictional names where confidentiality requires it, and say so plainly.

8.2 Methodology

The methodology section describes the design (exploratory, descriptive or explanatory; single or multiple case), the research questions and propositions, the sources of evidence, how the data were collected, and how they were analysed. It also describes the steps taken to ensure quality: triangulation, the case study database, and any checks by a second reader. Be specific about numbers: how many interviews, how many documents, how many hours of observation. A methodology section that says 'interviews were conducted' without saying how many, with whom, or how they were analysed, tells the reader nothing.

8.3 Findings, discussion and conclusion

The findings section presents what the study found, organised by research question or by theme, with evidence quoted and referenced throughout. The discussion then interprets the findings: it answers the research questions, compares the results with earlier work, and considers rival explanations. The conclusion states what has been established, what it means for practice, and what further research is needed. Keep

the three sections distinct in your mind even if your department allows them to be combined: evidence in the findings, interpretation in the discussion, and the answer in the conclusion. Blurring them is the most common structural fault in student case study reports.

Section	What it does	Rough share of the report
Introduction	Problem, question, purpose, why this case	5-10%
Context	Description of the case and its setting	10-15%
Methodology	Design, evidence, analysis, quality checks	15-20%
Findings	What was found, with evidence	30-40%
Discussion	What the findings mean	15-20%
Conclusion	Answer, contribution, recommendations	5-10%

[ ] The context section gives the reader enough detail to follow the findings.

[ ] The methodology names the design, the sources and the analysis steps.

[ ] Findings, discussion and conclusion are kept distinct.

[ ] Every section serves the research question.

Chapter 9: Writing Findings with Evidence

The findings chapter is the heart of the report, and it is where most case studies succeed or fail. Its job is to show the reader what you found, and to show the evidence for every important claim. A finding without evidence is an opinion, and an examiner will treat it as one. Write the chapter around your research questions or your main themes, one section at a time, and in each section present the evidence first and the claim second — so that the reader can see the grounds before the conclusion.

9.1 Using quotations and documents

Short quotations from interviews bring the findings to life and let the reader hear the participants in their own words. Choose quotations that illustrate a point clearly, keep them short — one or two sentences — and introduce each one with a sentence that says what it shows. Give each speaker a code, such as Teacher 2 or Parent A, rather than a name, and use the same codes consistently. Do not fill the chapter with long

blocks of quotation; the finding is yours, and the quotation is the evidence for it. Documents should be treated in the same way: cite them precisely, quote the key sentence, and give the date. A finding supported by a quotation and a document is far stronger than one supported by either alone.

9.2 Tables and figures in the findings

Use tables to summarise patterns that would take paragraphs to describe in words: how many interviewees mentioned each theme, how the cases compare, or the sequence of events in the case. A simple table can carry the structure of the findings and let the text concentrate on the meaning. Use a timeline or a diagram to show a sequence of events, or a simple figure to show how the themes relate to each other. Every table and figure needs a number, a clear title, and a reference in the text. Never present a table without explaining, in the text, what the reader should notice in it.

9.3 Reporting negative and unexpected findings

Report the findings that do not fit your expectations, and the evidence that contradicts your argument. A case study that reports only confirming evidence looks too neat to be true, and an examiner will suspect that awkward findings have been hidden. Unexpected findings are often the most interesting part of a study: they may point to a factor you had not considered, or to a limit of your explanation. Give them a proper section, present the evidence honestly, and discuss what they might mean. A researcher who reports a failure of their own proposition, with evidence, has done better work than one who hides it.

Worked Example: A findings paragraph with evidence

'Most teachers said the new homework policy added to their workload. Teacher 3 said, "I spend an extra hour each evening marking homework that used to take twenty minutes." Teacher 1 agreed, and the staff meeting minutes for 12 March record a request for the policy to be reviewed. Two teachers, however, reported no change: both teach small classes, and both said the marking load was already manageable. The evidence suggests that the policy increased workload mainly in large classes.' The paragraph makes one claim, supports it with two quotations and a document, and reports the exception.

- [ ] Every important claim is supported by evidence shown in the text.
- [ ] Quotations are short, introduced, and coded consistently.
- [ ] Documents are cited with dates.
- [ ] Negative and unexpected findings are reported, not hidden.
- [ ] Every table and figure is explained in the text.

Chapter 10: Ethics and Confidentiality

Case study research involves real people, often in their workplace, and it carries real ethical responsibilities. The researcher must protect the people who take part, respect the organisation that gave access, and be honest about what the study can and cannot promise. Most universities require ethics approval before fieldwork begins. Apply for it early, because the process can take weeks, and do not begin collecting data until approval is granted. An ethics section is a required part of the report, not an optional extra.

10.1 Informed consent

Every person who takes part must understand what the study is about, what they will be asked to do, how much time it will take, and that they may withdraw at any time without giving a reason and without any penalty. Explain this in plain language before the interview or observation begins, and get consent in writing. Where the study involves children, consent must come from a parent or guardian as well as from the child, and the school or organisation must also agree. Keep the signed consent forms securely, separately from the data, and do not include them in the report or the appendices.

10.2 Confidentiality and anonymity

Promise confidentiality only if you can keep it. In a small case — one school, one clinic — people may be recognisable even without names, because their role gives them away. Use fictional names for the organisation and for individuals, remove details that would identify someone, and be careful with quotations that contain recognisable details. Where a person is in a unique role, such as the only headteacher, consider whether a quotation can be used at all. Tell participants, before they agree, exactly how their identity will be protected and what the limits are. If the organisation asks to see the draft report, agree on this in advance, and be clear about what you will and will not change: correcting facts is reasonable; removing unwelcome findings is not.

10.3 Care in the field and after the study

Behave respectfully in the field: keep appointments, do not interrupt work unnecessarily, and thank people for their time. Store recordings, transcripts and notes securely, and do not share them with anyone outside the study. When the study is finished, report the findings honestly, including the limitations, and offer the organisation a summary of the results. Researchers sometimes forget that the people who gave their time deserve to know what the study found. A short, plain-language summary is a courtesy that costs little and is often appreciated.

[ ] Ethics approval was obtained before fieldwork began.

[ ] Written consent was obtained from every participant.

[ ] Fictional names are used and identifying details removed.

[ ] Data are stored securely and not shared outside the study.

[ ] The organisation will receive a summary of the findings.

Chapter 11: Worked Example: A Complete Fictional Case Study

This chapter presents a complete case study in outline, so that you can see how the parts of this guide fit together. The study is entirely fictional: the school, the people and the events are invented for teaching purposes, and any resemblance to a real school is coincidental. Read it as a model of structure and method, not as a report of real research.

11.1 The case and the question

The case is Riverside Primary School, a fictional school with 240 pupils, in a small town. Two years ago the school introduced a daily twenty-minute silent reading period. Reading scores improved in some classes but not in others, and the headteacher asked why. The research question was: 'How was the silent reading period introduced in Riverside Primary School, and why did it succeed in some classes and not in others?' The study was a single-case explanatory design, with the proposition that success depended on whether the class teacher read alongside the pupils, and the rival explanation that success depended on class size.

11.2 Evidence collected

The researcher interviewed twelve people: the headteacher, six class teachers, two teaching assistants, and three parents. She collected documents: the reading policy, the minutes of the meeting that adopted it, and two years of reading records. She observed the reading period in six classes, twice each, over four weeks. She kept all the material in a case study database, with a log of every contact and a copy of the written permission from the headteacher and the ethics approval from her university.

11.3 Analysis and findings

Coding the interviews produced four main themes: teacher modelling, time pressure, book choice, and pupil attitude. Pattern matching showed a clear pattern: in the three classes where the teacher read alongside the pupils, the teacher mentioned modelling in the interview, the reading records showed steady use, and observation showed pupils reading quietly for the full twenty minutes. In the three classes where the teacher used the period for marking, the reading records were patchy and observation showed pupils finishing early and talking. Class size did not explain the difference: one successful class had 32 pupils and one unsuccessful class had 24. The rival explanation was therefore rejected, and the proposition was supported.

11.4 Conclusion and recommendations

The study concluded that teacher modelling was the key factor in the success of the reading period, and that the policy had failed in classes where the period was treated

as marking time. It recommended that all teachers read alongside their pupils during the period, that the headteacher monitor the period by observation rather than by records alone, and that new teachers be trained in modelling before the period begins. The report also noted the limits of the study: one school, one term, and a researcher who knew the school, which may have affected what teachers were willing to say.

Worked Example: What makes this example work

Notice what the fictional study does: it names one case with clear boundaries, it asks one how-and-why question, it states a proposition and a rival, it gathers three kinds of evidence, it checks the expected pattern against the data, and it reports the finding that defeats the rival. Each of those steps comes from an earlier chapter of this guide. A real study that follows the same steps, with the same discipline, will produce a report of the same shape.

[ ] The fictional study follows the same steps this guide recommends.

[ ] Each finding is tied to a named source of evidence.

[ ] The rival explanation is tested, not ignored.

[ ] The limits of the study are stated in the conclusion.

Chapter 12: Common Mistakes and a Checklist

The mistakes below appear in case study after case study, in every subject. They are not mistakes of intelligence; they are mistakes of planning and discipline, and every one of them is avoidable. Read this chapter a week before submission, when there is still time to fix what it finds.

12.1 The ten most common mistakes

- No clear research question — the study collects everything and argues nothing.
- A case chosen for convenience that cannot answer the question.
- Only one source of evidence, usually a handful of interviews, with no triangulation.
- Findings presented without evidence, or with long unedited blocks of quotation.
- Description without analysis — the report tells the story of the case but never explains it.
- A proposition stated after the data were examined, so it cannot be tested.
- Rival explanations never considered, so the favoured explanation is untested.
- Real names or identifying details used, breaking confidentiality.
- Claims bigger than one case can support — generalising to all schools or all companies.
- Findings, discussion and conclusion mixed together, so the reader cannot tell evidence from interpretation.

12.2 The final checklist

Work through this checklist with the printed report in front of you. Tick each item only when you have checked it on the page, not from memory.

[ ] The research question is stated in the introduction and answered in the conclusion.

[ ] The case is named, its boundaries are written down, and access permission is recorded.

[ ] At least two sources of evidence support each main finding.

[ ] Propositions and rival explanations were written before analysis.

[ ] The methodology gives numbers: interviews, documents, hours of observation.

[ ] Quotations are short, coded, and used as evidence for findings.

[ ] Ethics approval and consent are described; fictional names are used.

[ ] Unexpected and negative findings are reported.

[ ] The report does not claim more than one case can support.

[ ] The report has been proofread, and a second reader has checked it.

Chapter 13: Conclusion

A case study is a demanding method, but it is also one of the most rewarding. It takes the researcher close to real life, to the people whose experience the research is about, and to the detail that makes the difference between a plausible explanation and a true one. The discipline it requires is simple to state and hard to practise: choose the case carefully, ask one clear question, gather several kinds of evidence, check each finding against more than one source, test your explanation against its rivals, and write the report so that the reader can see the evidence for every claim.

If you follow the steps in this guide, your report will stand up to examination — not because it is long, but because it is honest. It will show what you studied, how you studied it, what you found, and what that finding means. And it will do so in a way that respects the people who gave their time to your research. Choose the case well, listen carefully, and let the evidence speak. Good luck — and get writing.

Suggested Reading

The following are general, well-known kinds of works that students commonly consult for case study research. Check your university library for the latest editions, and follow your department's guidance on referencing style.

- Standard case study research textbooks: widely used methodology texts that explain case study design, data collection, analysis and reporting, with worked examples from education, business and the social sciences.
- General qualitative research textbooks: standard works on qualitative methods that cover interviews, observation, coding and thematic analysis, which are the main tools of case study research.
- General research methods textbooks: standard methodology texts used in most universities, covering research design, sampling, ethics and the reporting of research.

- Style manuals: the official manuals of the major referencing styles (APA, Harvard, Chicago, MLA) are the authoritative source for citation and formatting rules — consult the edition your department requires.
- Your university's thesis regulations and template: always the first and final authority on structure, word count, formatting and submission requirements.
- Your supervisor's recommended reading list for your subject: the most relevant source of all, because it is chosen for your specific topic and method.